

1100–1200

COURTLY LOVE AND CRUSADES

Fashion became increasingly flamboyant in the 12th century – a time of Crusaders, romances, and chivalry. Vivacious, sophisticated fashions cultivated in the south spread north from Mediterranean shores. Clothing became more seductively fitted, showing the body's shape for the first time. Tales of courtly love celebrated this effect, conjuring visions of figure-hugging silk gowns revealing embroidered chemises beneath laced sides. Garments were still based mainly on rectangular and triangular fabric cuts, but with lacing to crush straight shapes against the curved figure. Even ordinary women fitted their tunics more closely over waist, arms, and hips. Men's clothing also lengthened and tightened. Noble people of both sexes wore the bliaut or brial, a tunic made of fine, expensive silk with trailing hems and long sleeves. Accessories were long, pointed shoes, long hair, and elaborate cloaks and mantles. Religious and secular clothing styles began to differ.

SILK



Silk lampas

This fragment of silk lampas with a pattern of lions and harpies shows the extraordinary skill of 12th-century weavers. Luxury silk textiles were highly prized and expensive, with alluring names like samite, Alexandria, ciclaton, taffeta, and lampas recorded in romance tales of the times.

Silks were either rich and stiff or valued for their delicacy, transparency, and light draping. Silks made ideal high-status gifts, as they were light and unbreakable during long-distance travel.



Round fillet holding fine veil

V-neckline

Wide, hanging sleeves

Pleated or finely gathered long skirt of bliaut

Long lines When women finally revealed their hair, they added false hair into their plaits for dramatic length. French noblewomen wore bliauts of the finest Oriental silks; fine pleating contributed to the vertical illusion.



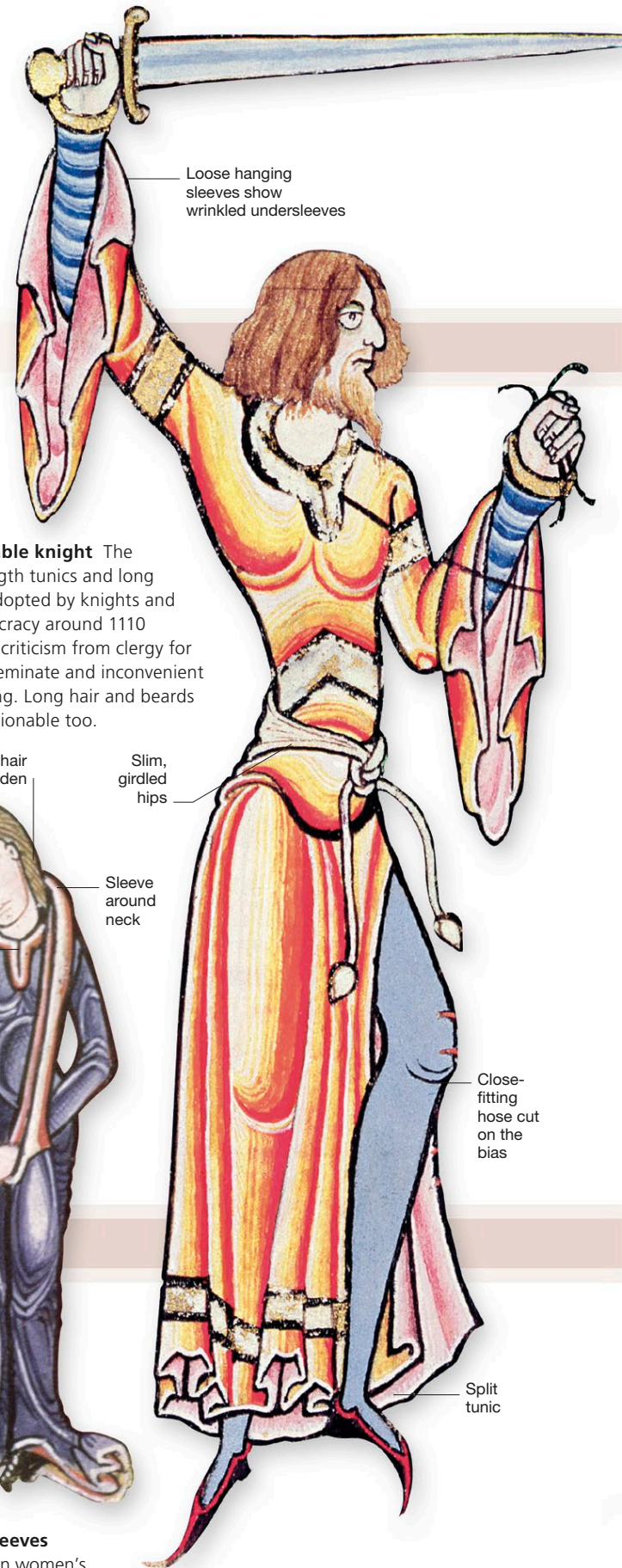
Uncovered hair for maiden

Slit neckline

Contrasting lining

Girl's pendant sleeves

Extreme fashions in women's dress, which included sleeve cuffs so wide they trailed on the ground, were fashionable from c.1150. Thinner fabrics clung to the body, outlining the shape.



Loose hanging sleeves show wrinkled undersleeves

Fashionable knight The ankle-length tunics and long sleeves adopted by knights and the aristocracy around 1110 attracted criticism from clergy for being effeminate and inconvenient for fighting. Long hair and beards were fashionable too.

Slim, girdled hips

Sleeve around neck

Close-fitting hose cut on the bias

Split tunic